Supavit Pitaknarongphorn, UID: 505718503

Prof. Matthew Pierce, MGMT 169

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1 - Introduction

As a Computer Science and Engineering major, I joined the Undergraduate Minor in Entrepreneurship (UME) with the goal of understanding how technical skills can be applied beyond the classroom, particularly in the world of startups and innovation. I wanted to explore how software and engineering could be leveraged not just to build products, but to solve real-world problems and create value in business settings. My internship at UniShack gave me the perfect opportunity to put this into practice. Through my internship, I was able to apply class frameworks, contribute to both business and technical initiatives, and grow into a more well-rounded and effective professional. This paper reflects on that experience, highlighting what I contributed, what I learned, and how the UME curriculum prepared me for it.

1.1 - What is UniShack

UniShack is a student-focused housing platform based in Los Angeles that streamlines the off‑campus apartment search by gathering verified listings, virtual tours, and honest reviews. Whether you're a student browsing for year-long apartments or short-term sublets, UniShack lets you filter by rent, location, and amenities at no cost, ensuring you only see trusted, up‑to‑date options. Born from the founder's own experience of moving three times in one summer, the platform aims to simplify housing decisions with tools like roommate matching, exclusive student deals, and rigorous landlord verification. It started at UCLA and is now expanding to other campuses across California, including USC, SDSU, UCSB, UCI, and UCSD. UniShack

offers free sublet listings for students, as well as property management services for landlords seeking quality leads.

1.2 - How I Got the Internship

I found the internship opportunity at UniShack through a UME email where the founder had shared a posting seeking student interns. Interested in the company's mission and eager to contribute, I proactively reached out to the founder with my resume and a tailored cover letter, requesting a meeting to discuss how I could support the team. After our conversation, the founder welcomed me to the team and offered me the choice between two roles: a computer science-focused position involving the development of a web scraper to collect property manager contact information, or a business development position centered on creating a plan for expanding UniShack to new campuses. Given that this internship was part of my UME coursework, I opted for the business development role to better align with the program's objectives. However, as the internship progressed, I ultimately took on both responsibilities, contributing to both the technical and strategic growth of the company.

2 - My Contributions

As part of my internship at UniShack, I was given the opportunity to work on both strategic and technical initiatives that contributed directly to the company's growth. My responsibilities centered around two key areas: business development and technical automation. I developed a repeatable strategy for campus expansion, and then built a web scraping tool to support that strategy through efficient data collection.

2.1 - Business Development

For the business development task, I focused on creating a scalable plan to expand UniShack's presence beyond UCLA to other campuses such as USC, UCSD, and SDSU. This

involved designing a standardized onboarding process for both student users and property listings in new regions. To operationalize this strategy, I developed a detailed flowchart outlining each step of the expansion process, including the number of outreach emails and phone calls to be made, expected response rates, and standardized communication templates such as email and call scripts. This framework also included logistical considerations for managing property data and partnerships, allowing UniShack to replicate its expansion model efficiently across multiple campuses.

2.2 - Webscraper

After completing the business development plan, I recognized that manually gathering contact information for outreach operations would be time-consuming and inefficient. To address this, I explored automation and initially experimented with a Chrome web scraper extension. However, I quickly found that it lacked the flexibility I needed for customizing data extraction. To overcome this limitation, I transitioned to building a Python-based web scraper using Selenium and BeautifulSoup, which allowed for more control and precision. I coded the scraper to collect property manager contact details from relevant websites and successfully delivered a functional tool to the founder, streamlining the data collection process for UniShack's expansion efforts.

3 - What is a Webscraper

A web scraper is a tool used to automatically extract data from websites. It works by sending a request to a web page, downloading its HTML content, and then parsing that content to locate and collect specific pieces of information, such as text, images, or links, based on the structure of the page. Web scrapers can be programmed to navigate through multiple pages, fill out forms, and interact with website elements to gather large amounts of data efficiently. Tools

like Selenium and BeautifulSoup in Python are commonly used for this purpose, allowing developers to simulate browser behavior and extract structured data from otherwise unstructured web content.

4 - What I Applied

Throughout my internship, I was able to apply several key concepts and skills I gained from the Undergraduate Minor in Entrepreneurship. This section highlights two areas in particular where those lessons came to life: the integration of my technical background into real-world business applications and the importance of adaptability in a fast-paced startup environment. Both played a significant role in shaping my experience and impact at UniShack.

4.1 - Technical Skills

I joined the Entrepreneurship minor to complement my Computer Science and Engineering major, with the goal of learning how technical knowledge can be applied in real-world settings. Through my internship at UniShack, I had the opportunity to bridge these two domains and see firsthand how my coding and problem-solving skills could directly support business goals. Whether it was automating data collection through a custom web scraper or contributing to strategic planning for campus expansion, I was able to apply my technical background in meaningful ways. This experience deepened my understanding of how software development and automation can create tangible value in an entrepreneurial context and reinforced the importance of interdisciplinary thinking in building effective startups.

4.2 - Flexibility

One of the key lessons I took away from the Undergraduate Minor in Entrepreneurship is that in the entrepreneurial world, team members must be flexible and willing to take on a variety of tasks beyond their formal roles. Startups often operate with limited resources, requiring

individuals to wear multiple hats and adapt quickly to shifting needs. Embracing this mindset, I remained open-minded throughout my internship at UniShack and welcomed any task assigned to me. This flexibility not only helped me grow but also opened the door for me to contribute to both the business development strategy and technical implementation through web scraping, allowing me to gain a well-rounded experience and deliver value across different areas of the company.

5 - What I Learned

Beyond the technical and strategic work I contributed, I gained deeper insights into how successful businesses operate and what it takes to thrive in a startup environment. This section highlights two key takeaways from my experience: the importance of creativity in developing revenue strategies and the critical role that clear, honest communication plays in professional settings.

5.1 - How to Be Creative with Revenue Streams

One important lesson I gained from this internship is that creativity can be important in building a successful business. I learned to think beyond traditional models and explore innovative ways to generate revenue. For example, while most apartment search platforms focus on standard income streams like booking fees, advertisements, or priority listings, BruinShack takes a more creative approach by offering marketing packages and social media management services to property managers. This unique strategy not only adds value to their partners but also opens the door to new possibilities in how apartment search platforms can operate and differentiate themselves in a competitive market.

5.2 - Communication

Another valuable lesson I learned from this internship is the importance of communication in a real-world work environment. In school, I was used to completing assignments independently and simply submitting the final result, often without much collaboration or progress updates. I also tended to avoid discussing challenges with supervisors, fearing that admitting difficulties might reflect poorly on me. However, during my time at UniShack, I realized that consistent communication is essential for effective teamwork and project success. I learned that keeping my team and supervisor informed about my progress—and being honest about any obstacles—helped build trust and allowed for timely support or adjustments. This experience taught me how to communicate more transparently and confidently, which is a crucial skill for any professional setting.

6 - Conclusions

In conclusion, my internship at UniShack offered a deeply enriching experience that allowed me to apply the frameworks and lessons from the Undergraduate Minor in Entrepreneurship in real and meaningful ways. From developing a strategic expansion plan to building a technical tool that supported that strategy, I gained firsthand insight into how startups operate, adapt, and grow. More importantly, I learned to embrace flexibility, enhance my communication skills, and think creatively about business challenges—skills that will undoubtedly serve me well in any future endeavor. This experience has not only strengthened my technical and entrepreneurial capabilities but also reaffirmed my passion for working at the intersection of technology and business innovation. As I move forward in my career, I will carry with me the lessons of adaptability, collaboration, and initiative that defined my time at UniShack and in the Entrepreneurship minor.